KATESHAWHOMEOFGOLDSOUTHAFRICAEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, we're in Khan at the IGTM, the International Golf Travel Market, and we're on the Africa stand here, and I've run into the fabulous Joan Shaw. She's representing the home of Golf Africa, presented by George Tourism, and Joan, welcome to the program. Thank you very much.

Thanks for having me. Now, it's great to have you on the show, and I've seen you around, you're such a fantastic personality around here, and you help everyone on the Africa stand. Tell us, first of all, before we get into the home of Golf, tell us about the George area, absolutely beautiful area of South Africa.

So, George is what we, we'd say the capital of the Garden Route, but it's not a very big city. We don't even have 300,000 citizens, but it's a beautiful, natural city that is concerned to have a sustainable future. We preserve our water, we have alternative energy sources, and we basically sit in a national park that preserves our beautiful floral heritage.

Close to Neisner, close to Oatsorn, close to Marshall Bay, all the great attractions of the Garden Route are just within a few kilometers away from us. How are you finding the show over here in Khan? Is it your first time here, or are you coming for a year? We try to come every year, but I haven't actually been since Portugal, so we missed a year, and actually when I arrived, I thought it was a little bit quiet, but the business has been exceptional, really, really enthusiastic operators looking for new markets, which is just what we're after. Tell us about Home of Golf Africa, I mean it's a magnificent place and a magnificent project that you have.

It is indeed, so we're a bit cheeky, saying we're the home of golf in Africa, but we really feel we deserve the title, because George alone in our little city has got six 18-hall golf courses, and then we have two nine-holes, we have three golf academies, and over a hundred businesses that just supply the golf industry, so you can imagine quite an economic driver for our city. We then reached out to our neighbors, both Neisner and Marshall Bay, and said would you like to join hands with us and become the home of Golf Africa? And so we have 12 world-class golf courses within a 100-kilometer stretch that you can play and stay and really experience the best of South Africa. In amongst that is also the South African number one course, Fancourt at the Lynx, and all the beautiful Fancourt courses, but they're also supplementary courses for every budget and every level of player, so from beginners, elderly people, youngsters, it's all there.

And apart from golf, the George area, it's a jumping-off point to all these fabulous experiences, tell us about that. It is indeed, so just in George, there are many things to do outside of golf, including beautiful hikes, we have a mountain that hosts an Ironman trail run every year, a hundred miler if you're nuts enough to do that, we have a lot of events, we have a career to go cycling race, and so a lot of people come to George, people say why would I go to George, you know, why wouldn't I go to Cape Town, I said you must do Cape Town, but George's where Cape

Town comes on holiday. Right, so that's pretty good recommendation, isn't it? Yeah, so it's like a really cool place to be for the Cape Town people.

Absolutely, away from the city, we have a beautiful magnificent natural environment, we call the garden route, and it's nature's garden, so anything that nature can offer you is there on your doorstep, and like you say, as a springboard for the area, you could do a boat on knives there and oysters, you can do the beautiful sparkling wines in Plittenberg Bay, you can go over the mountain on beautiful routes to Oatshorn, do the world famous Kango Caves, you can zip line over the ocean in Marsel Bay, see the cradle of human origin, there's just so much to do and see that you actually need quite a long time, just for the garden route. And have you had any Aussies over there visiting? Oh, we get a lot of Aussies, we of course have a lot in common with Australians, we like to barbecue, outdoor living, I visit Australia a lot myself, I told you I'm married to a Kiwi, so we do New Zealand and we often do Australia, and we'd like to see more Australians, I know that our seasons are the same, so your summer is also our summer, which is our high season, but for the best deals, I'd recommend if you haven't got kids at school, try our winters, they're beautifully mild and the rates are really, really low, our exchange rate is I think 11 round now to the Aussie dollar, which brings a lot of value. And how can people get there to you flying, do they fly from Perth or where can they fly from, all major cities go to you? Absolutely, you can fly from any major city, in Australia straight into Cape Town or Joburg via Qantas, we always fly Qantas, great airline, Qantas also has an arrangement with a local operator, so you can check your bag in in Sydney or Perth or wherever you are, and you can pick it up in George if you're coming straight to George.

But there are many ways to skin a cat, so you don't have to fly straight to George, you can fly into Cape Town, drive up the worlds, AA Magazine has just nominated our garden route to the best scenic route to drive in the area free, so it's within say eight or nine hundred kilometres, you could have absolutely the best of what South Africa can offer you. And tell us about one or two hidden gems in George that the locals know about, but maybe tourists should check out. Well for sure, there's a little train that goes up our mountain and I think some tourists do know about it, it's called the Powervan, but you can pack your own picnic or you can ask them to order your picnic in and it goes up our beautiful Ertonekwa mountain and it stops at the top and you can have a picnic and if you're so inclined you can ask, book a hiking tour from up there, so the operator will meet you, take you on a hike through our beautiful Fainbos area, through the vineyards, you can have beautiful Ertonekwa wine with a light lunch and then they bring you back to George by vehicle.

There's also great little craft shops, things you can only find in George, we have a little pottery called Wonky Way, it's very famous in the UK, people come from the UK with empty bags to fill them up to take them back. We're a dairy farming area, we grow vegetables, so a lot of the country markets are just stunning, you can just get any fresh produce that you want. We can't finish without mentioning the fabulous wines that South Africa produced, do you have any

wineries in your area? We certainly do, our Ertonekwa region only actually has one wine farm, but surrounding us there are plenty and like I said Plet goes magnificent probably and we've also got quite a lot of boutique wine shops where you can actually do it tasting, see what you like and then order it later in the restaurant or take a few bottles home with you.

Fabulous and how can people find out more? We're talking with Joan Shaw and she's from the home of Gulf Africa presented by George Tourism and Joan Shaw from the home of Gulf Africa presented by George Tourism in South Africa. How can people find out more online about you and George Tourism itself? Okay great so for the home of Gulf which is a collaboration of our region you can go to the website homeofgolf.africa or you can look at what's on around and about George's and events calendar so you know if you've got special interests we have great rugby team and George so if you want to come for the rugby you can find every single event at visitgeorge.co.za Joan thank you so much for being on the program and do say hello to to say Kia ora to your husband you're from New Zealand and we'd love to see you again in Australia sometime. Thank you Geoff it's been great to chat.